The Puppy and the Hippie

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A Warm Call

COL-306301

A Warm Call

Charlton's Home

Charlton: ... Yes, of course. I totally understand how much you love our little Pickles.

The man struggles to hold the slippery phone with his shoulder as he scrambles to open the perfectly-sealed can.

On the newly updated package of the can, a relunctant smile was extorted from the Border Collie.

Charlton: But, you see, as his best friend, his will is what I value the most ...

Charlton: So, in this case, I would respect his own wish ...

Wendy: Woof?

Pickles: Woof, woof. <*Sorry, Wendy.*>

Pickles: Woof woof woof. <*I think I should be mostly held accountable for your throw-and-catch time being substantially diminished.*>

Pickles lays down on the floor next to her.

Pickles: Woof woof woof. <*After all, these calls has eaten up a significant amount of the day.*>

Wendy: Woof woof!

Pickles: Woof, woof woof woof. <*Yes, they are the reason for the emergence of those oddly-flavoured canned food.*>

Pickles: Woof, woof woof? <*But at the end of the day, why would humans think it is a good idea to add sea bass in canned dog food?*>

Wendy approves of this comment. She lets out a resigned sigh through her nose and crouches down on the floor.

The two dogs lay on their bellies, shoulder to shoulder, staring at the man who is now giving a passionate speech on his love for dogs to the other end of the phone.

Charlton: Who can say no to his smooth fur? He is the cleverest dog I've ever seen.

Charlton: But he prefers a quiet life, my friend. I have just turned down an offer for him to be the brand ambassador of the pet hair brush 2 minutes ago ...

Charlton: I'm so sorry, I ...

Charlton: ...

Charlton: What did you say?

Charlton: Oh wait, the one before that, no, not this one, before that too ...

Pickles: ...

His black, furry ears prick up.

Pickles: Woof, woof woof. <*This look on his face ... I think I have seen it before.*>

Pickles: Woof ... <*Wendy ...*>

Pickles turns around to his friend, but the bulldog has ignored his call and trotted outside the door with her favorite bouncy ball in her mouth.

Charlton: No way, France? Really?

Charlton: And on a c-cruise ship ...

Charlton: Well, sure, no problem at all ... He is going to love this ... I bet he would ...

Pickles: ...

Pickles: *sighs*

The standing ears slowly droop.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Perhaps at this point ...>*

Pickles: *whimpers* *<I shouldn't be surprised by his doings anymore.>*

TO BE CONTINUED ...

A Floating APPLe Pie

COL-306302

Outside Charlton's Home

Charlton: Alright, tooth brush ... Hmm, the red one is better ...

Pickles: ...

In the garden by the street, the Border Collie cranes his neck for a sight of the man who is busy packing in the room.

The window is too high for a dog; through it, Pickles can only see a small fraction of the room.

Charlton's worn leather travel bag sits on the bed with a wide opening. Surrounding it, there are clothes in all colors scattered on the bed, as if they were just vomited up by the bag.

Pickles: Woof ... Wuu. *<I believe I've made the right decision to stay in the garden as he packs ... The room is unbelievably messy now. Charlton is never a quick decision maker.>*

Pickles: Woof. *<Though I don't know what's so hard about choosing clothes. He only has to choose from a narrow selection of colours.>*

Pickles: Woof, woof woof. *<But perhaps I was misled by my limitation as a dog. This exemplifies the point that the view of the others, since it is not a part of "the self," is unknowable to us.>*

Pickles: Woof ... *<But these things are the least relevant now ...>*

Pickles tries to put his front paws onto the windowsill. His vision is now improved, though to a limited extent.

Unsurprisingly, the rest of the room is as messy as the bed.

Pickles: Hwu, woof ... *<Charlton, do you have a moment to talk ...>*

Charlton: Oh! Pickles!

Charlton's head appears in the window from the right.

Pickles: Woo, woof woof. *<Oh, I was looking for you.>*

Pickles: Woof, woof ... *<In fact, about that tour in France ...>*

Charlton: A-ha, look at your wagging tail! I know exactly what you're worried about.

Pickles: Woof woof, woo— *<That's a relief. I ...>*

Charlton: Ta-da!

Charlton: The Meditations or the "dog football with Pickle's paw print" ...

Charlton: Which one do you choose?

Pickles: ...

Pickles tries as hard as possible not to look too confused.

Pickles: Woo ... *<I don't see the necessity to choose between the two ...>*

"Doggie": The puppy thinks it's a hard choice.

Pickles: ...

Charlton: Oh, that surprised me ... But you don't have to choose!

Charlton: We will take both!

Pickles: Woof, woof ... *<Err, actually ...>*

Charlton's head disappears in the window.

Charlton: Don't worry! Being narcissistic is not a bad thing!

Pickles: ...

Charlton: VIP tickets for "Queen Elizabeth" ... You don't get this everyday!

The dog retrieves his paw from the windowsill. He can only see that worn leather bag again.

Pickles: ...

Pickles: ... Omm. *<... I think I still have much to improve, regarding my skill of communication.>*

It's not a big garden. The Border Collie slowly moves to the side closer to the front door.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Everything seems to have changed.>*

Pickles: Ahh-choo ...!

The streets are quiet in the morning.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<But nothing seems to be changing.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<If our changes exert no effects to reality, what is the meaning of our actions?>*

The plants in the garden are freshly pruned. Black and white has therefore stood out more significantly on the grass.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Maybe something did change after all. Say, he turned down those advertisements for my sake.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<But I also had to put up with those strange flavour drinks which irritated my tongue and make recommendations I don't believe.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Or should I ask the right question ...>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Why would traveling excites Charlton so much?>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Perhaps I am unfamiliar with other ways to get along with human except for compromising.>*

There are indeed so much more experience he needs to gain in life—for example, to get used to the quietness breakers.

???: Woof! Woof woof!!

Dog barks come from afar.

Pickles: Woof? *<Wendy?>*

Pickles: Woof woof? Woo ... *<The smell? Hm ...>*

Pickles: Woo ... Woof woof. *<True ... There is a sweet smell in the air.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<But Charlton has been occupied with packing. He wouldn't have the time to bake an apple pie.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*What is it then ...?*>

APPLe: The amount of exercise this apple has taken today has exceeded the recommended amount for a day.

Pickles: Woof woof?! <*Mr. APPLe?!*>

A red ball-like sphere with a sweet smell floats by, easing at a well-controlled speed.

The bulldog chases after it strained to the apple, charging at full speed. She is not even aware of the bohemian silk scarf attached to her hind leg.

Pickles: Woof, woof! <*Wendy, stop!*>

This is a lot to ask for Wendy. What else can be a better target to chase after than a moving ball-like fruit that gives off great smell?

Pickles: Woof, woof. <*Oh, we got problems.*>

TO BE CONTINUED ...

Relativity of Misunderstanding

COL-306303

Carnaby Street

APPLe: Thank goodness.

Wendy: Woof!

The result is clear; running is not a strength of bulldogs.

She is deeply bewildered by the situation; one of her hind legs is pulled up by the silk scarf and straightly pointing up to the sky.

Pickles: Woo ... Woof, woof woof. <*Lift it higher—ok, it's wrapping around your paw.*>

Wendy: Woof, woof woof!

Pickles: Woof, woof woof. <*Yes, I understand what you mean, Wendy.*>

Pickles: Woo ... Woo-woof woof. <*It does have a smell similar to apple pie ... and that is because it—sorry, this gentleman is an apple.*>

The Border Collie throws back his head and finally releases Wendy from the muddle.

Wendy: Woof woof woof?

Pickles: Woof, woof woof. <*Yes, a flying apple.*>

Pickles: Woof ... <*It's going to take some effort to thoroughly explain this ...*>

Pickles: Woof, woof woof. <*... but to put it simply, apples are not all the same.*>

Pickles: Woof. <*This apple happens to be one of the inedibles.*>

Wendy: Woof ... woof?

Hegel is apparently too much for a bulldog.

Pickles: Woo ... Woof woof. <*I'm sorry to sadden you ... But I believe Charlton will prepare you something more delicious than an apple.*>

The bulldog gets herself together. Pickles turns and looks up in the air.

Pickles: Woof, woof woof, woof. <*Good day, Mr. APPLe. I didn't expect us to see each other again.*>

"Doggie": Greetings.

APPLe: Greetings to you, little puppy.

APPLe: This APPLe appreciates your help.

APPLe: We keep running into each other ... It has almost become an inevitable event that takes place spontaneously.

APPLe: This APPLe was really planning for the worst.

APPLe: But it would definitely upset the captain, if I were captured by that lady puppy.

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Although you have a captain friend, you strike me as a loner.>*

Pickles: Woo, woof. *<To which I am relatable.>*

Pickles: Woof woof. *<On the art of getting along with others, I'm still a humble student.>*

Pickles: Woof woof, woo ... *<When one's personal needs conflict with external expectations, where will we find the master solution ...?>*

"Doggie": The puppy had a fight with a friend too.

Pickles: Woof? Woo ... Hmm ... *<Pardon? No, this is not true. I didn't have a fight with Charlton ... It was merely a ...>*

APPLe: I'm sorry if I have misled you. There has been no unpleasant event happened between Captain and this apple.

APPLe: Just that recently, Captain has been targetted by some strangers who would make eerie noises and her drinks supply has therefore become inconvenient to secure.

APPLe: This apple is merely running simple errands.

He shakes the invisible plastic bag. It rustles in the air.

APPLe: By the way, this new package of Dr. Papper with a puppy on it is quite popular these days.

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof. *<So I have mistaken.>*

APPLe: So what happened between you and this little bulldog?

APPLe: Perhaps this APPLe can humbly provide some advice.

Pickles: Woo ... Woof ... Woof, woof ... *<No, not with Wendy ... In fact ... it was because Charlton has agreed to do a gig on a cruise tonight ...>*

"Doggie": The puppy is asking for your opinion.

Wendy: Woof woof?!

Pickles: Woof, woof ... Woof ... *<Yes, it is true, Wendy ... Charlton probably hasn't had the time to share this news with you ...>*

The bulldog rounds her eyes in disbelief. She starts to spins around out of excitement.

"Doggie": The puppy will travel far.

APPLe: Is that so?

APPLe: But this APPLe begs to differ. It may be unwise to just leave your friend behind after having a fight with them.

APPLe: Your friend will be worried about you.

APPLe: What's more ...

APPLe lowers his voice, hinting with a meaningful look at the bulldog which wants to leave immediately. Unfortunately, however hard he strain his eyes, the expression is hardly observable to others.

APPLe: In this APPLe's opinion, a secret plan shouldn't be discussed in front of the concerned entities.

Pickles: Woof ... Woo. *<No ... I have decided against the runaway. >*

Pickles: Woo ... Woof. *<Charlton is looking forward to this trip ... yet I don't feel ready to stand in front of a massive crowd.>*

The bulldog is fidgeting. She cannot wait for a minute longer to go pack her bag.

Even she has nothing else to pack but that bouncey ball.

Pickles: Woof woof! Woof ... *<Oh, Wendy! Please, don't pull my tail ...>*

Pickles: Hmm ... *<I'm still talking to Mr. APPLe ...>*

"Doggie": The puppy feels uneasy.

APPLe: This APPLe is certain that, even between captain and I, there used to be tensions.

APPLe: Sometimes it was about our tastes for music, sometimes it was about food. Sometimes Captain mistook me for deserts and almost ate me while I was taking a nap ...

APPLe: But most of the issues between friends can be solved through communication. Based on my personal experience, if this rule is true for an apple, it should also be true for a puppy.

Pickles: ...

APPLe: Perhaps this is going to be too sophisticated for you—outside the realm of science, when it comes to the matter of sentiment, we have to admit that sometimes we don't have to fully understand our friend to be there for them.

Wendy: Woof woof!

Wendy is prowling up and down anxiously.

Pickles: Woof woof ... Woof, woof. *<Yes, we are leaving soon, just give me a minute, Wendy ... I really appreciate your advice, Mr. APPLe.>*

Pickles: Woof, woof ... Woof. *<I know it's difficult for one individual to understand the other ... and it's equally hard to understand them only through verbal communication.>*

Pickles: Woo ... Woof. *<Nevertheless ... I think I should give it a try.>*

"Doggie": The puppy accepted your suggestion.

APPLe: It's my pleasure to be of help.

APPLe: But ...

APPLe: Your friend seems to have left.

Pickles: Woof? *<Do you mean Charlton?>*

Pickles tilts its head, confused.

It is weirdly silent here.

APPLe: If this APPLe's eyes serve him well, your friend went towards Regent Street.

APPLe: Even though 30 minutes ago it was her who almost consumed me as snacks, I have to admit she has one adorable little tail.

Pickles: Woof. *<Oh no.>*

Pickles: Woof! *<Wendy!>*

Regent Street

London apparently doesn't anticipate the sudden wind.

Police Officer: Hey! Keep order!

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<What is going on ... ?>*

The queue before them goes on forever.

A group of fluffy, colorful cumulus "clouds," slowly rolling forward, flood onto Regent Street. Music, slogans, and flower petals pour down on the asphalt pavements like a shower of rain.

Young Man in Understated Clothes: No more Establishment! Peace and love!

Police Officer: Blimey, why are so many people here this time?

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<This seems to be a gathering about art.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Such a complex smell ... >*

Pickles: Woof, woof! *<Wendy, Wendy!>*

Wendy: Woof! Woof woof!

A muffled voice comes from afar.

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Oh, I think I've spotted her.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<She seems trapped. >*

Pickles: Woo, woof ... Woo ... Woof. *<Ah, that silk scarf ... It's a shame that I have ripped it apart ... perhaps its owner is right in the crowd.>*

The Border Collie lowers its body, agilely dodges the clubs and kicks and breaks through the siege of the police.

Young Man A: Oh, hey look! Here is a puppy!

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<I'm sorry. It's not a good time to make acquaintance.>*

Young Woman A: Hahaha! A free puppy! Aww, it's fluffy!

Young Woman A: This must be how Utopia would feel like!

Pickles: Woo, woof. *<This is not the best petting I've ever had, but I guess this is more of a friendly gesture than an action for my own comfort.>*

Pickles: Woof, woof, woo ... *<However, sorry, I have a business to attend to ...>*

Pickles: Woo, woof. *<Oh, this is bad.>*

The tiny tail of the bulldog disappears in the crowd.

More hands and legs gathers around.

Pickles: ...

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I haven't felt such a great amount of passion since the Flurry Puppy Games.>*

The smell of Wendy is getting thin in the air.

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof. *<Excuse me.>*

His fluffy hair flutters in the breeze. An indigo blue glow flows around his body.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I hope pushing your high-spiritedness further won't ruin this get-together ...>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I just need you to move along a bit faster.>*

There comes a minor disturbance in the crowd.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Looks like my trick has worked out well.>*

A small swirl emerges in the middle of that colorful "cloud."

Pickles: Woof ... *<But ...>*

The Daydreaming Man A: Oh, OH!!

The Daydreaming Woman A: The battleship turns into a flower! Whoa ... is it rose?

Pickles: ...

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<This is odd. Their emotions don't seem to be the only thing that has been affected.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I don't reckon myself to be capable of creating illusions.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Must be something else did this to them ... But for now the most important thing is to find Wendy ...>*

"Pop."

Pickles: ?

Pickles flicks his furry ears. Even in a place noisy as this one, it captures a faint voice.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<This is the noise of ... bursting soap bubbles?>*

TO BE CONTINUED ...

Bubble Crash

COL-306304

Bubble Crash

Wendy: Woof woof!

Pickles: Woof! *<It's Wendy!>*

Pickles: Woof ... Woo ... Woof ... *<Sorry ... excuse me ... my apologies ...>*

The crowd in disorder forms an unbreakable cage around him.

The excited bulldog completely ignores the calling from behind, making her way quickly and nimbly by people's feet.

Her furry little tail shows up on and off from between the legs. Clearly, she is making more progress than her black-and-white peer.

Wendy: Woof woof woof!

Pickles: Woo? *<You've already made it through the crowd?>*

Pickles: Woo, woof, woof ... *<Sorry, please wait up, I'm not doing too well here ...>*

Pickles: Woof! *<Oh!>*

The Border Collie stops abruptly, saving himself from bumping into the streetlamp.

???: Come, friends of the new world! Masters of the Utopia! Future of mankind!

He looks up at where the voice come from. On that streetlamp, a man in a sloppy, bright-colored shirt inhales deeply.

???: Phew ...! *blows bubbles*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<This voice ...>*

The bright kerchief tied on his forehead is almost blazing under the sun.

???: Excellent, the new formula with amphisbaena egg liquid is far out!

???: This is an era belongs to us! Come! Let me be the witness of your wonderful world!

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I remember him. He is ...>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Oh! So the strange reactions of the crowd were caused by these soap bubbles.>*

Pickles: ...

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<This is bad.>*

That little swirl spreads out in the "cloud."

This is turning into a thunderstorm.

Wendy: Woof, woof woof!

Outside the moving crowd, the bulldog who has lost h her friend barks helplessly.

This is a problem too big for her to solve.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I feel discomfort of various kinds on my ribs.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<It wasn't a good idea to use my arcane power after all.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<... I wouldn't have foreseen the misfortune to encounter these strange soap bubbles. My paws are uncomfortably sticky, thanks to them.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<The bitter taste of life caused by ignorance—humans call it "regret.">*

Pickles: Woof! Woof. *<Oh! Easy, watch my feet.>*

The Daydreaming Man B: Here is a ... burp, Pogeyan ...

A strange man who has been staring at the soap bubbles for an excessively long time looks down and rubs Pickles roughly.

Pickles: Hmm, woof, woof ... *<Sir, you have mistaken, I'm not ...>*

The Daydreaming Man B: Aha! I found Pogeyan!

Pickles feels a steady push exerted on his ribs, and his view suddenly brightens up.

The man holds the Border Collie high over his head.

Pickles: Woof, woo ... *<Oh dear ...>*

A height that seems hazardous enough for the Border Collie.

Pickles: Woo ... *<Oh, this is too high ... I, I see the sun ...>*

Pickles: Woof, woo, woof ... *<This is very uncomfortable, please, let me down ...>*

The man looks deliriously delighted.

The soap bubble, with a glow of rainbow flowing over its surface, lands on his wet, black nose.

"Pop."

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Is this ... a bubble? They seem like living creatures ...>*

A doziness gradually muddles his mind before he realizes it.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<What a beautiful sphere ... almost perfect ... like the one that Euclid has ...>*

"Pop."

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Oh ... I smell parchment.>*

A door, in bright gold, slowly opens before him.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Am I ... in a white robe? Is this ... Greece?>*

Before the arch of the Academy of Athens, the wise ones wait in two lines, standing on both sides.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<This is the perfect city ... now, should I go crouch in the wine barrel?>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Or looking at the moving shadows on the wall of a cave?>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<No. I ought to seek knowledge of the star inside an apple ... or wonder about that meaningful hole on donuts.>*

The noise of the crowd is distant and unclear, as if there's a thick film exist between him and the people.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Am I home? Back to Greece?>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<What is this place?>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Who am I, and why do I exist?>*

???: Whoa, watch out, my friend! Don't trip me in this Utopia!

???: You ... emm? A dog here?

???: Ah! I know this black-and-white hair ...!

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<The headwears, and the excessively long hair.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Oh, religion could be philosophical.>*

"Doggie": The puppy agrees.

Diggers: Yeah, I'll bet. You furry little monster who stole the thunder of the New Age Art.

Diggers has his back to the crowd and drops to his knees before Pickles. He gently squeezes his paw.

Diggers: Hmm, but feel these paws ... perhaps they do deserve some public attention ... briefly.

Diggers: Ahem, you showed up at this street party, for which you should be praised ...

Diggers: Ha, but I'm not that stupid. You just got lost with your master, right?

Pickles: Woo, woof? *<I don't quite follow this conversation about master. Are we discussing the cognitive self?>*

Diggers: Oh, that sounds like a no.

Pickles: Woof. *<I feel I should depart for Greece as soon as possible.>*

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<They have invited every soul who is hungry for philosophy and they are waiting for me.>*

"Doggie": The puppy will travel far.

Diggers: Oh.

Diggers: Travel?

The man who has long lead a vagrant life raises his eyebrow.

Diggers: Like what I have been doing, to be a follower of freedom?

Pickles: Woof, woof, woof. *<I think you take me wrong. I seek a path to pursue the truth, not to wander around without purposes.>*

"Doggie": The puppy wants to chase its dream.

Diggers: ...!

Diggers: Oh, wow! Are you really just a hound?

Pickles: Woof, woof, woof. *<Biologically, I'm a shepherd dog, a Border Collie.>*

Diggers: My soulmate is a black-and-white hound!

Pickles: Woof ... Woo? *<I believe you should deepen your understanding of this world ... do you crave for the truth?>*

"Doggie": The puppy wants to seek the source of everything.

Diggers: Oh, so you are a fundamentalist dog in art!

Diggers: But, you are right ... I can at least agree with you on this.

Diggers: As they say, "Paris is the capital of art" ...

Diggers: Even though those patronizing French people always look unpleasant with everything ...

Diggers: We can't deny they are the experts when it comes to romance.

Diggers: But if you ask me, they need a revolution there ...

Diggers: ...

The man tightens his grasp around pickles' paw.

Diggers: Hey ... speaking of which, you've reminded me, little fella ...

Pickles: Hm?

Diggers: We shouldn't just settle for one party!

Diggers: To promote art, we need to go to the real capital of art!

He gets back on his feet indignantly, as if he's about to take on an important mission.

Diggers: Imagine, when our speeches at Place de la Concorde spread across the city ...

Diggers: The new ideas will strike the foreign city like a hurricane!

Pickles: Woof? *<A hurricane?>*

Diggers: What an excellent idea!

Diggers: You and I are of the same mind, we should form an unbreakable alliance!

Diggers: Come, comrade.

Diggers: Action is the precondition of changes in art!

Pickles: Woo? *<Hm?>*

The "cloud" parts and moves pass them.

Diggers: Now ... let's see ...

The man stands with his hands on his hips, checking on the mess and feeling exalted.

Diggers: Now, where to find the key to open the gate of the capital of art?

TO BE CONTINUED ...

A Shoe Left Behind

COL-306305

A Shoe Left Behind

The Dock

Diggers: Phew ... finally here we are—the harbour!

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof. <*It's sea bass.*>

Pickles: Woof. <*But I don't think I have ever tried anything with sea bass.*>

Pickles: Woof, woo? <*How marvelous ... is this a trick my subconscious mind pulls on me?*>

"Doggie": The puppy is surprised.

Diggers: Comrade, be as surprised as you want!

Diggers: One of the skills you would acquire in a tramp life is to keep the map in your head.

Diggers: You have a lot to learn, little one.

Pickles: Hmm ... <*I don't understand why we are here.*>

"Doggie": The puppy is not familiar with it.

Diggers: Oh, you've never been here?

Diggers: Then you have missed out on so much!

Diggers waves a fragment of the brochure in his hand; on it the word "cruise" and "Paris" are exaggeratedly circled in red.

Diggers: You can find all kinds of sales promotions in the morning market, for the distributors here never think about people's spending power!

Diggers: Which explains, this baby!

He raises his arms, at the end of which that piece of paper rustles in the wind like a brittle ribbon.

The harbour has become quiet again after the market is over in the afternoon.

Diggers: Hmm, though we have missed the best time to collect flyers ...

Diggers: But I'm assuming there would be a dozen of people who couldn't be bothered to take all these colorful papers home ...

Diggers: Now it's your turn, little one!

He reaches for the dog's nose with that broken brochure.

Pickles: Woo, woof. <*Mister, there is no way I can sniff out traces from such a complicated smell on this paper.*>

Pickles: Woof, woof ... <*This is pointless. I suggest you read more about biology ...*>

"Doggie": The puppy can't be of help.

Diggers: Oh, that's a shame.

Diggers: Well then, perhaps you can keep an eye on the paper nearby? If you see any of these cheap magenta ones ...

Pickles: Woo, woo ... <*I don't have a sufficient number of cones in my eyes to tell red from other colors.* >

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof. <*However, I know a way that is more efficient.*>

The dog slowly casts his eyes down.

Diggers: Oh, you want a nap!

Diggers: Leave it to me then, comrade. The reliable Diggers will start ... from the rubbish bins!

The man turns around dramatically, fully unaware of the indigo glow behind him.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*This is strange. What is happening to me ...? Is my arcane power failing me?*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*The brochure ... yes, I ought to see where the brochure ...*>

Pickles: Woof ... Wuu ... Om? <*But what are these ... Are, are they whi-white ... sneakers?*>

???: Wendy ... Why ... here alone?

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*Who is talking?*>

???: Pickles ... Lost?!

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*Pickles?*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*Should I ... know this name?*>

Pickles' eyes fluttered open.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*This ... this is bizarre.*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*My perception is beyond my control ... but what am I looking at?*>

Diggers: Ah-ha!

The man who almost dived into the rubbish bin straightens up.

Diggers: Here, comrade! Look what I have found!

Diggers: An intact copy of our flyer!

Diggers: Check out what's on the left page—oh! A trip on the ocean loaded with surprises, a wonderful cruise to Paris!

Diggers: Good news for us, this is exactly what we have read from the bits and pieces!

Diggers: Then the departure time is ...

Diggers: Tonight?!

Diggers: Oh, this is fate!

He seems to be in high spirit.

Diggers: A miraculous coincidence ... my purpose!

Diggers: Phew, good! Now, the price! Let me see ...

Diggers: ...

Diggers: No, no no ... I must have gotten it wrong.

Diggers: One, ten, a hundred ...

Diggers: ...

The brochure he just picked up falls on the ground again.

Diggers: Apparently, you can't name a price on art.

Diggers: ... But you can name one on its door.

Diggers: I believe this is the destined tribulation we have to overcome to furfill our purpose ...

Diggers: We have to find another way.

Diggers: Like a ... more artistic way ... say, stowaway?

Diggers: Oh! I gotta say, it sounds romantic!

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Hm?

In the reflection of his eyes, there is another cruise trip printed on the right page of the brochure.

Pickles: Woof? <*Greece?*>

Pickles: Woof ... Woof. <*It leaves tonight ... Perhaps I can leave with this good mister.*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*A cruise to Greece ... no, to home.*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*On board I will be the ship in the ship, a mist named Theseus ...*>

Diggers: Hey, comrade, are you listening?

Diggers: You seem a bit odd.

Pickles: Woo, woo, woof. <*Sorry. For a reason I don't know, I can't stop thinking about philosophy.*>

Pickles: Hmm? <*But why would I ever need to stop?*>

Diggers: Em? It's already ...

Diggers: Damn it, time is not on our side.

Diggers: Let's hope the party will come to this street shortly.

Diggers: Of course, it'd be even better if they can go to the harbour ...

Diggers: Okay then, there's nothing I can't tackle with my Reflective Bubbles!

???: Woof, woof.

A voice comes from across the river.

Pickles: Woof? <*Em?*>

Pickles: Woof? <*This is a name long lost in memory ...*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*That's not right.*>

???: Pickles? Piiiiiickles!

The Border Collie's ears prick up.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*I know this voice.*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*It's the same one I just perceived ...*>

Diggers: Comrade?

???: There he is!

???: Woof, woof woof!

Pickles: Woof ... Woo. <*No, I don't remember any apple pies ... it's too sour to my taste.*>

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof? <*Sour?*>

Charlton: Oh my god, it's Pickles!

The figure across the river is still vague to his eyes, but Pickles has vigilantly put his tail up to the air.

Wendy: Woof, woof woof!

Next to the breathless man, a ball of fur is hopping about anxiously.

Charlton: Wendy, it's really him! Thank goodness I found him ...

Charlton: He seems fine ... Fantastic ...

Charlton: Holy, I can't cross the river!

Charlton: Pickles! Stay there and don't move!

The man quickly scrambles through his pockets.

Charlton: Look!

Charlton: It's your favourite Lectures on the Philosophy of History!

Pickles: ...!

The white tip of his tail wags in the air.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Who is that man?>*

Pickles: Wuu mm ... *<He's wearing the white sneakers ...>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Oh. Are those HIS shoes?>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<He seems to know me well.>*

The dog walks a few steps towards the river.

Pickles: Woof. Hm ... Woof. *<I like his voice. His smell ... is pleasant too.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<He is too far away from me. Why doesn't he come closer?>*

Diggers: Move along, comrade, time waits for no one!

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Yes, yes, I know.>*

The dog takes a step towards the river and hesitates. He then spins around, whining and feeling vacillated between the two men.

Charlton: Pickles ... I need to get over there!

Pickles: Woo, woo ... *<Good sir, if not for the fact that I have committed to an important cause ... >*

Charlton still eagerly and anxiously tries to find a way to go across the river. On the other bank, the dog in black-and-white keeps looking back at him.

Charlton: Oh please please please don't move!

The man beseeches the dog.

But he has to watch him walking out of his sight with a strange man.

Charlton: Oh no ...

Wendy: Woof, woof, woo ...

Charlton stares at them in a daze, and slowly sits on the ground.

Wendy: Woof woof ...

He holds the poor bulldog in his arms; some wet, slimy marks soon appear on the dog's hair.

Charlton: He abandoned us ...

Wendy: Woof?

TO BE CONTINUED ...

A Planner with No Plan

COL-306306

A Planner with No Plan

Sergeant: This block asks for help!

Sergeant: Darn it! Why are these loafers so ...

Several police vehicles wait at the wharf, forming a cordon.

The revelry has lastest for a whole day, yet the crowd seem as energetic and in high spirit as they were in the beginning.

Sergeant: Randy, you go over there! Don't let the paraders disturb the tourists!

Wharf

By the corner of the street, a furtive-look man waits in the shade with a Border Collie in his arms.

Diggers: The fire of art is forever burning, you ignorant followers of a dead era.

Diggers: And the fire takes different forms ... look, an improvisation in three minutes! The intense version of my classic work Dreamy Reflective Bubble !

Diggers: Seems like mistaking sandwiches for the regular ingredients might not be a bad thing.

Pickles: Woof. *<I hear Heraclitus' voice in your words. >*

Pickles: Woo? *<But did you overlook the part where he demonstrated logic while you read?>*

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<In my opinion, most of your actions lack reflections.>*

"Doggie": The puppy considers you as unwise.

Diggers: I beg your pardon?! Comrade, my feelings are hurt.

Diggers: This is not where you would find an artist's wisdom! Our creations rely on moments of inspiration that cannot be replicated!

Pickles: ...

Diggers: Hm? What's the staring for?

Police Officer: Keep orders here! They're coming!

Diggers: Oh, yes, they're on their way!

Diggers: Remember, proceed as planned!

Pickles: Hm? Woof ... *<Hm? You have never told me about any plans ...>*

"Doggie": The puppy feels confused.

Diggers: Exactly ... !

The man gallantly charges out of the shades like an arrow released from a long-drawn bow.

Diggers: Freedom needs no plan ...!

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof ... *<I have a bad feeling about ...>*

Young Passer-by: Hey look! Those Reflective Bubbles, here they come again!

A first it was just a familiar, almost unnoticeable tiny burst.

"Pop."

Sergeant: Hey you! Get down here!

Diggers: Sorry! But the flag of art will not be lowered!

Then some shoutings come from the man in strange clothing who is tightly holding on to the streetlamp.

Young Man Staying off the Ground: Oh, dear ...! I knew it all the time that the Mount Olympus is not by the Aegean Sea. It is here! In the bubble!
Right beneath my feet.

The street has become the ocean of bubbles.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<The world is slowing down.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I get a little itch to my nose ... Why ...>*

Diggers: Come, mate! Join us!

Diggers: Phew ...

Police Officer: Oh ... ohhh ... mum's oat meal ...

Sergeant: Wake up, Randy! You bastard, don't think you can get away!

Young Passer-by: Woo-hoo! Look what's in the bubble! Corpse flowers grow on the tank in forest!

Diggers: Comrade! Over here!

The road is heavily blocked by people, but they quickly find a simple solution to it—a fantastic shoe print appears on top of the sergeant's car.

Sergeant: What ...

Diggers: Come on, jump!

The bubbles float and flutter about, dancing around the dog's nose; some of them slowly drift down to his front paws, then onto his belly.

Pickles: Woof, woo ... <*Sorry, I'm feeling funny in my stomach ...*>

He had a similar feeling before—when he was exhausted in the hopeless pursuit of knowledge and fell to the floor.

Pickles: Woof ... Wuuu ... <*O, Okay ... I think I can ...*>

The Border Collie jumps up at his full stretch.

He elegantly hops into the air and stays there for a brief moment. In that lapse of a few seconds, he sees in the corner of his eyes a figure of a man.

Pickles: Woof? <*Who is that?*>

"Da." *Paws land on the ground*

In the service area of the wharf, the figure of a man draws every bit of his attention.

Charlton: I was wondering if you can give me some time?

Two cruises are anchored in the wharf. The ark to Greece is right under their noses.

Pickles: Woof? <*Is he the friend that I haven't made?*>

Pickles: Wuu ... Woof? Om ... <*Haven't ... made? D, Doesn't sound right ...*>

Yet on the other side of the chaotic crowd, a muffled but familiar voice comes into his ears.

Charlton: I saw him in the harbour quite close to here. I've also asked the police for help ...

Charlton: But they said they were out of people today so they can't help us ...

Pickles: Woof? Hm ... <*What is he talking about? I can't hear him clearly ...*>

He tries to shake off the dizziness.

Charlton: The worst situation is that we can't even join the event ...

Pickles: Woof, woof ... Woo ...? <*My, this vertigo ... and you are ...?*>

Pickles: ... Woof? <*... Charlton?*>

The bubbles suddenly burst and turned into a watery mist. It happens within seconds, as if someone has magically made them disappear at a snap.

As the doziness withdraws, Pickles feels himself shuddered.

Pickles: Wuu ... Woof! Woo! <*Oh ... Oh! That's—Charlton!*>

His vision and hearing has become incredibly clear.

Wendy: Woof, woof woof!

He looks at the wharf in chaos and disorder.

Pickles: Woof? <*Why am I here?*>

Pickles: Woof ... *special thinking noise* <*I must be staring at those bubbles for too long ... and it's not a good idea to get myself in trouble while I was sleepwalking ...*>

Sergeant: Stop that guy! He is going aboard!

Tourist A: Oh my! The car hit the street lamp!

Sergeant: What? Crap! Who put Randy behind the wheel?! I just said he can take a rest in the car!

Pickles: Woof. <*Not to mention that the situation seems quite troublesome.*>

Pickles: Hm ... <*This is ...*>

Pickles: Woof?! <*Six o'clock?!*>

Pickles: Woof, woo. <*Not good, the cruise is leaving ... The time for Charlton and I to communicate has been largely reduced.*>

Pickles: Woof, Om. <*Had I known better, I would have told him sooner what I really think.*>

Pickles: Om, wuu, woo ... <*I need to find him. Yes, before the cruise sets sail ...*>

The happy crowd grabs the police for hugs and raises them over shoulders; the luggage bags of the travelers are also thrown into the air.

The police car which bumped onto the streetlamp gives off wisps of thick smoke.

Pickles: Woof ... Woof! <*Charlton ... Hey!*>

Pickles: Ommm, wuuoof ... <*We ... We need to talk ...*>

And amongst the disarray, the dog moves quickly between people's legs.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*The party is not over yet ...*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*The size of human's entertainment is beyond imagination.*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*But what happened today has made me realized that I haven't close the intelligence gap between myself and a perfectly rational dog.*>

He climbs over three piles of luggage bags and jumps over an advocate of freedom who is fully involved in a kiss with the earth.

Pickles: Woof ...! <*Charlton ...!*>

Pickles: Woof! <*Oh!*>

He stops before it's too late.

A police flies over him, inches away to his nose, in a perfect projectile.

Pickles: Woof, woof. <*Sir, this was way too dangerous.*>

Pickles: Woof. <*Human should embrace the doctrine of Mr. APPLe's Flight Safetyism.*>

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*But it's good enough, I'm so close to get at Charlton's sock ...*>

He opens his mouth, trying to stop Charlton by pulling his socks to the other direction as he always does.

In the next moment, he feels a familiar push under his ribs.

Diggers: Keep yourself busy, you stuffy old gentlemen!

Either his head or the entire world goes into spinning.

Pickles: Woo ... <*Oh ...*>

The man doesn't waste a second. He snatches up the Collie and flees towards the cruise.

Pickles: Woof. <*Not anymore.*>

The cotton socks is quickly withdrew from him.

Diggers: How come there are two ships?

Diggers: Nevermind, this is not what we need to worry about.

He ignores the marks on the sides of the two ships and directly heads to one of them.

Diggers: Freedom—!

He carries his ally on the shoulder like carrying a big soft furry sack.

People are shouting, screaming, and running around. Nobody tries to stop them from setting foot on the gangway.

Diggers: Whoa, comrade, calm down, your wagging tail keeps slapping my face.

Pickles: Woof, woof. <*Let me go, mister.*>

Pickles: Woof! <*Charlton!*>

In the service area, the man who is in the middle of a difficult conversation with the staff suddenly feels something. He jerks up his head and looks around.

Pickles: Woof! <*I'm here!*>

Diggers: The great New Art revolutionary has boarded the ship towards the holy land!

Sergeant: Stop that guy!!!

Diggers: And goes into exile with his comrade!

Pickles: Woof! ... Woof? <*Please put me down! ... What ally?*>

Diggers: Run, let's go!

A long history of being a fugitive helps one to increase his physical capacity significantly.

Diggers dismisses the panicky passengers on the deck and thrusts into the cruise.

thud

A poor waiter walks by with a plate of food in his hand. But before he sees anything, a figure carrying something on his shoulder dashes by, which makes him jump and nearly tosses the food off the ship.

Staff on the Cruise: Whoa!

Staff on the Cruise: ... What just went by?

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*This is all too awful.*>

His white claws tightly fix on the denim cloth on the back of the running man.

They are moving at a speed not too fast for a dog, unless the dog is just recovered from dizziness.

A corner follows another. Hallways in different lighting. The panicky faces of the crew.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*I want this to be over as soon as possible.*>

At the end of the corridor, a door is tightly shut.

Diggers: No entry? Right, this is the place!

Diggers bursts into the room, keeping at his full speed. Inside the poorly-lighted room, there is a forest of distribution boxes.

The dog is feeling dizzy again from the bumpy run. He lifts his head, finding a thick layer of pipes attached to the ceiling—so thick that the room has become even more cramped.

Pickles: Woo. <*I think you shouldn't be in here.*>

"Doggie": The puppy is dissatisfied.

Diggers: Hm?

The man turns and stares at the dog on his shoulder, finding his comment hard to accept.

Diggers: That was my fastest run ever! You could have said something nice, little fella!

Pickles: Woof. *<And I believe the speed IS the problem.>*

Pickles: Hm, woof? ... Woof?! *<No, why are you staring at me? ... Aren't you supposed to look ahead while running?!>*

Pickles: Woo ...! *<Dangerous ...!>*

"Doggie": The puppy gives its warning.

Diggers: Warning? To me?

Diggers: Comrade, you shouldn't ...

"Pang!"

A pipe sticking out in the air puts an end to this short-lived escape.

Pickles can't help closing his eyes as they fall.

Pickles: Hm, woo. *<My, sounds like a nasty trip.>*

He crawls out from under the fainted man and gives his head a gentle poke.

Pickles: Woof ... *<The pipe is still shaking from his trip ...>*

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<... but I see no wounds on him. I hope he will be awake soon.>*

Pickles: Woof. *<Though I don't recall we have ever formed an alliance ...>*

Pickles: Woo, woof. *<... this is going to be the end of it. I'm sorry.>*

He looks back at where they came from.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Now ... let's hope that the door to the deck is still open.>*

TO BE CONTINUED ...

Bouncey Ball

COL-306307

Bouncey Ball

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I reckon this is the right way.>*

Deck

A little head pops out among the waving passengers.

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Oh, is this sea breeze?>*

The sea breeze ruffles his long black-and-white hair. A gleam of indigo glow slowly fades out from the tip of his hair.

He narrows his eyes.

Pickles: Woo ... *<Phew ...>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<This is probably the most relieved and comfortable moment today.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Sadly I don't have the time to enjoy it.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<Is Charlton still around?>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*I hope he didn't leave ...*>

He looks down from the edge of the deck.

Pickles: ...?!

Pickles: Woo? <*An anchor boat?*>

Tourist B: Hm? Here is a puppy!

Tourist C: It's like the one on the soda can!

Pickles: *special thinking noise* <*Perhaps I should get off the ship first.*>

Pickles: Woof, woof ... <*Oh, too late ...*>

???: PIIIIIICKLEEEEEEEES!

Pickles' ears move.

Pickles: Woof? <*Charlton?*>

The dog looks over at the shore.

Charlton pushes through the crowd, striving to get closer to the cruise.

Staff: Hey mister! We're retracting the gangway!

Charlton: I have the ticket!

The man, holding his luggage bag in one hand, tries to push through the ticket barrier.

Staff: Sir, it's too dangerous!

Pickles: Woof! <*Charlton!*>

Pickles: Woof. Woof, woo? <*He saw me. Unbelievable, do humans even have such good eyesight?*>

Charlton: Pickle! Do NOT move this time!

Charlton looks anxious and panicky.

The gangway creaks.

Staff: Sir, please calm down, it's too dangerous near the edge ...

Wendy: Woof woof!

The man wrenches himself free from the staff's constraint. He looks up at the dog who tries hard to stick out his head, and looks down at the dark water.

One end of the gangway is drawing a horizontal semi-circle in low air as it moves away from the dock. It is coming their way.

Charlton: *deep breath* No time to think about that!

He makes up his mind, clenches his fingers around the old leather bag and takes a deep breath.

Charlton: Wendy, jump!

As a bulldog, she's outstandingly bouncy.

Wendy: Woof woof!

Her hind paws firmly land on the deck. Behind her, Charlton kicks hard against the fender pile.

Pickles: Woof, woof! <*Watch out, Charlton!*>

Charlton: WHOAAAA!

His legs are shaking. The gangway under his feet is making a shrill, piercing noise.

Charlton: It's shaking!!

Staff: No sir—The gangway! Stop retracting!

Wendy: Woof woof!

The bulldog also perches shakily by his feet.

Charlton: Ok, ok! I'm on my feet now.

Charlton: Wendy, ready ...

Charlton throws a red bouncey ball to the ship.

Charlton: Run!

Charlton: Pickles!! My pickles!!

The man rushes onto the ship. The dog has run to the gangway to welcome him. He throws his arms around the dog.

Wendy: Woof woof!

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Wendy, you found the ball.>*

The bulldog drops the bouncey ball and pushes the breathless man with her nose.

Charlton: It's my fault only paid attention to the stupid luggage ...

Pickles: Woof, woo? Woof, woof. *<Charlton, are you alright? Your heart is pounding. Take a deep breath.>*

Pickles: Woof ... *<This is not a good time to talk ...>*

Pickles: Woof ... *<You should rest ...>*

Charlton: I shouldn't have forced you to join the event, but I thought you would enjoy it ...

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Indeed I'm not a fan of clamorous crowds and meeting with strange people.>*

Pickles: Woof. *<Nor am I interested in endorsing pet food.>*

"Doggie": The puppy doesn't like the crowd.

Charlton: Oh ...

He seems lost and sad.

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<But you have also turned down many other endorsements offers for my sake, though you always fail to understand the exact reason I dislike them.>*

Pickles: Woo ... *<Oh, maybe ...>*

An apple comes into the dog's mind.

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof, woo ... *<Maybe Mr. APPLe was right. We don't have to get to the bottom of what exactly the other person is saying ...>*

"Doggie": The puppy %^&* ...

Charlton: Hm? Is the translator broken?

Pickles: Woof. *<Charlton, though you aren't very good at analyzing and reflecting on the problems ...>*

Pickles: Woof. *<... I have to admit you have a good instinct on how to be a wonderful friend. >*

Pickles: Woof. *<I should try to be more like you in that aspect.>*

"Doggie": The puppy wants a hug.

Pickles: Woof?! Woof, woof ... *<A hug?! No, I didn't say ...>*

Charlton: Oh no, it IS broken.

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Despite your reaction, I don't think I'm a very indifferent and distant dog.>*

Charlton: But you might be freaked out, little guy ...

He pulls the dog into a hug and rubs his neck hard.

Charlton: It's ok buddy, we're together again!

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woof ... *<Em ...>*

Pickles: Woof. Woof, woo? *<We can respect each other even if we can't fully understand each other. This is good, isn't it?>*

honking ...

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Oh, shoot. A cruise has set sail.>*

Pickles: Woof ... Woof? *<Maybe ... It is the one to Greece?>*

Charlton: Luckily, we made it!

Pickles: ... Woof, woo. *<... Oh, well, fine. >*

Charlton: I owe you an apology. I didn't expect that you dislike the event so much that you would leave us.

Pickles: ...

Charlton: But I promise you ...

Charlton: I will try to make it up to you! Cancel the panel ... I assume the host won't ...

Reception Room

Staff: That is not possible, Mr. Charlton.

Charlton: Oh ...

Charlton: Um ... That's not what I expected ... Haha ...

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I'm not surprised by this outcome.>*

Staff: I hope you understand that it is very irresponsible to cancel an event in the last minute.

Pickles: Woof, woo, woof ... *<It's okay, Charlton. If it is just one panel ...>*

Staff: We've made great effort on this panel and even prepared a warm-up on the cruise today.

Pickles: ...

Charlton: Today?!

Staff: Yes ... we tried to contacted you earlier but my colleague couldn't get in touch with you.

Charlton: Well, um, there was an accident today ...

Charlton: ...

He awkwardly scratches his head.

Charlton: Is there any chance we can ... ?

Staff: Absolutely not.

Staff: If you insist, then I'm afraid you need to pay liquidated damages of ten times of the cost of the event.

Charlton: Ten times?!

Charlton: That's ...

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<There have been too many accidents occurred in one day.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<First the dreamlike meeting with the philosophers, then the strange gentleman who is passionate about bubbles ...>*

Pickles: ... Woo. *<... Hold on.>*

The dog gets up.

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<I have a not necessarily appropriate but definitely effective solution to all these.>*

"Doggie": The puppy has a new idea.

Charlton: Pickles?

The Border Collie dashes out of the door without looking back.

Charlton: Pickles!!

TO BE CONTINUED ...

Transfer Ceremony

COL-306308

Party Transfer Ceremony

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<No entry.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<And the smell ... this is it.>*

Pickles: *special thinking noise* *<I hope Mr. Bubbleman is still here.>*

Mechanical Room

Diggers: Hm ...

Diggers: Didn't have ... Sandwich ...

Pickles: Woof, woof! *<Unbelievable, he is still conscious!>*

Pickles: Woof. *<Your curious constitution must have assisted your luck.>*

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Wake up, Mr. Bubbleman.>*

The dog pulls his kerchief.

Diggers: Hm ...

Pickles: Woof. *<Physical stimulation doesn't seem to be effective.>*

Pickles: Woof. *<You might need some moist stimuli.>*

Pickles: Hmm ...

Pickles: Woof, woo. *<But I don't like the smell on you. It is too complex and overwhelming.>*

Diggers: Oh ... um ...

Diggers: Is it the good rain of art ...?

Diggers: ...

Diggers: But why does art smell like saliva?

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Great, your eyes are open.>*

Diggers puts in a great effort to focus on the ceiling.

Diggers: Oh the headache ... Where am I?

Diggers: Inside the door of a new world?

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<I'm afraid not, you are inside the gate of the mechanical room.>*

Pickles: Woof ... *<That violent knock on your head earlier probably has done some damage to your brain ...>*

"Doggie": The puppy is worried about you.

Diggers: Hm?

Diggers: Hey! It's my comrade!

Diggers: You are safe and sound!

Diggers: Aha!!

Diggers: Your safety has drawn the successful end of this great action led by this pioneer of the era!

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<You are such an optimistic person, this is great.>*

Pickles: Woof. *<It should help your following actions.>*

"Doggie": The puppy invites you.

Diggers: Huh? Invite me?

Pickles: Woof. *<Apparently, the host hopes to bring something different to the audience.>*

Pickles: Woof. *<Look what I found in the hallway.>*

Diggers: Oh ... A party ... about you?

Diggers: HEY! It's not fair!! I was the enlightener, but I had never been invited to give a speech!!

Diggers: People—they'd rather listen to a hound's barking?

Pickles: Woo. *<I have given up correcting your misunderstanding of animals.>*

Pickles: Woof, woof, woo. *<But sir, if you like, you are more than capable of filling people's hearts with passion with your arcane skill.>*

Pickles: Woof, woo. *<So that they may enjoy themselves there, instead of expecting me to entertain them.>*

"Doggie": The puppy wants to transfer the party to you.

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Thank you so much for being accurate at this crucial moment, Doggie.>*

Diggers: What? For real?! Holy moly!

Diggers: A public solo speech that I have dreamed of ...

Diggers: Hell—This is perfect! Thanks for your generous act, my comrade!

Diggers: But ... I hope I still have enough soap bubble solution ...

Pickles: Woof. *<This shouldn't be a problem.>*

An indigo gleam flashes in the dog's eyes.

Pickles: Woof. *<What happened this morning told me that I can be of help with that.>*

"Doggie": The puppy is itching to try.

Diggers: Oh, why are you so hyped?

Diggers: Alright, alright!

Diggers: Let's move, comrade!

Deck

Charlton: Good girl, Wendy! Bring it here!

Wendy: Woof woof!

Charlton: Now this place is for us only! Everyone went to dinner.

Wendy: Woof ...

The bulldog sinks down next to Charlton.

Wendy: Woof ...

She doesn't seem to be interested in the game.

Charlton: Hm? You hungry?

Charlton: Just wait for a bit longer ... Pickles will be back any minute ...

He hears the sound of quick, light footsteps from behind.

Charlton: OH! Pickles!!

Charlton: I knew you would come back you smart little guy!!

He sticks his hands into his thick hair, just like what he has done hundreds of times.

Pickles: Woof, woof. Woo? *<Oh, it feels nice. More on the chin, please?>*

Charlton: All the staff went for you!

Charlton: But don't you worry. If you want to hide until the evening ends, I'll do my best to help!

Pickles: Woof, woo. *<I think you don't have to worry about that. I just came across them.>*

Pickles: Woof ... Hm ... Woof. *<They are enjoying their time ... umm ... in the "Dreamy Party for New Art.">*

Pickles: Woof, woof. *<Probably I got the name wrong, but it is okay.>*

Pickles: Hm, woof. *<Based on my experience, they will be pretty occupied throughout the entire time of our show.>*

Charlton: *Sigh*

Charlton: I'm sorry that I didn't persuade them as I promised ...

The evening sea breeze is blowing in their faces.

Charlton: Haha, it's hard to know what you're thinking. I've never met anyone as special as you are.

Charlton: Are you only attracted by those books I can't understand ...?

Pickles: ...

Pickles: Woo. *<I can't foretell what my future preference will be.>*

Pickles: Woof. *<Perhaps one day I will learn to love sea bass canned food and throw-and-catch.>*

Pickles: Woof, woof ... Woof. *<But for now, I'm satisfied with those books and your apple pie—though sometimes it tastes a bit too sour. >*

Pickles: Woo ... *<I also feel the same about this trip ...>*

Pickles: Hm ... *<Sitting in the sea breeze with you ... is almost as comfortable as I was when I read The Republic for a second time.>*

Pickles: Woo. *<... is almost as comfortable as I was when I read The Republic for a second time.>*

"Doggie": The puppy wants to sit with you.

Charlton: Hm, can we even find a repair shop for this translator?

Pickles: ...

Charlton: But if that's what you want, let's sit together!

Wendy squeezes her head into Charlton's arms to join them.

Wendy: Woof woof woof!

Charlton: Alright girl! We'll grab some sandwiches downstairs very soon!

Charlton: But for now—

The moonlight sheds on the sea, giving the water a shimmering glow.

Charlton: Let's just sit and enjoy the night!

The noise of the happy cheering crowd faintly comes out from the cabin.

-- Seems like everyone has enjoyed their night to the fullest.

Pickles: Woof!

THE END